Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Sharon Olds's "He Comes for the Jewish Family, 1942"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the emotional crescendo that underscores the theme and the tone of Olds's "He Comes for the Jewish Family, 1942" include

aesthetics,
aesthetic distance,
diction,
free verse,
imagery,
irony,
objective correlative,
simile,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

Sharon Olds's poem is a fairly straightforward portrayal of the benighted barbarity that often finds occasion and opportunity in uniformed authority. The student might recognize, additionally, something of the distance that is established in the poem's lack of emotively charged diction. The writer might perceive a level of irony in this disconnect.

The contestant has been asked to develop a discussion of the crescendo that begins as a chronologically placed knowledge-in-anticipation and ends with the silence that follows the inferred loudness of the brickwork's crushing of the daughter's cello (lines 20-21), the brickwork having been given the role of active destroyer. The idea that a fellow human being, even one intent on a personal role in a genocide, could play the active role in the destruction of that which is party to beauty, the cello, is presented as unfathomable through the aesthetic distance defining the speaker's own role. Thus an awareness of the narrative quality of the poem's setting up the final lines' "they stood and / stared at him in terror" might inform the essay response.

The triad that is the victimizer, the victims, and the instrument representing, quintessentially the terminal—both primitive and sophisticated—completeness of human expression, the shared-across-cultures love of music, is lined up as target, the cello in unexpected inclusion. The anticipated dehumanization, torture, rape, and murder is trumped, in the eyes of the speaker and of the victims who are about to be taken to their deaths, by the unanticipated destruction of, in the concrete, the beauty of music, arguably so much a part of both Jewish and German traditions. The perceptive student might sense in the German's action an envy of the artistry and beauty that is frequently synonymous with Jewish musical accomplishment. The well-read contestant might reference Hannah Arendt's "banality of evil."